What does Secularism mean?

Secularism means an attitude of tolerance towards other religions and peaceful co-existence of citizens belonging to different faiths. It is a policy of neutrality and equality by the states towards all religious communities.

Secularism is the principle of separation of state and religion or more broadly no interference of the state in the matters of religion and vice-versa. This means that every citizen is free to propagate, practice, and profess their faith, change it or not have one, according to their conscience.

Atheism - is a lack of belief in god and gods.
Secularism - is non – interference of the state in religious affairs and vice-versa.

Objectives of Secularism

- One religious group does not dominate another.
- Some members don't dominate other members of the same religious community.
- The state does not enforce any specific religion nor take away the religious freedom of individuals.

A simple statement by poet Iqbal illustrates the secular view "Religion does not teach us animosity; We are Indians and India is our home!"

12th Rock Edict, Ashoka



Emperor Ashoka was the first great emperor to announce as early as 3rd century BC (BCE) that the state would not prosecute any religious sect. In his 12th Rock Edict, Ashoka made an appeal not only for the tolerance of all religious sects but also to develop a spirit of great respect towards them.

The Characteristic Features of a Secular State

Principle of Liberty – the state permits the practice of any religion.

Principle of Equality – the state does not give preference to any religion over another.

Principle of Neutrality – the state remains neutral in religious matter.

A secular state is the one in which the state does not officially promote any one religion as the country's official religion and every religion is treated equally. It gives to every citizen not only the equal right to freedom of conscience but also the right to profess, practice and propagate any faith of their own choice. The state observes an attitude of neutrally and impartiality towards all religions. In a secular state no one is given preferential treatment and the State does not discriminate any person on the basis of their religious practices and beliefs. All citizens are eligible to enter government service irrespective of their faith. There should be absolutely no religious instructions in educational institutions and no taxes to support any particular religion.

Importance of Secularism

The concept of secularism evolved in India as equal treatment of all religions. We need secular state to maintain peace and harmony between people of various religious ideologies. It is a part of democracy, which grants equal rights



The Mughal emperor Akbar followed the policy of religious toleration. His propagation of Din-i-Illahi (Divine Faith) and Sulh-e-Kul (Peace and harmony among religions) were advocated for religious toleration.

Constitution and Secularism

Secularism is the part of Indian Constitution. The makers of the Indian Constitution were

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